

The Most Magnificent Thing

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****Author:**** Ashley Spires

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Source: `The Most Magnificent Thing (Ashley Spires).pdf` (37 PDF pages; story on PDF pages 6-34)

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This is a regular girl and her best friend in the whole wide world. They do all kinds of things together. They race. They eat. They explore. They relax.

He unmakes things. She makes things.

One day, the girl has a wonderful idea. She is going to make the most MAGNIFICENT thing! All she has to do is make it, and she makes things all the time. Easy-peasy! She knows just how it will look. She knows just how it will work.

First, she hires an assistant.

Next, they gather their supplies. They set up somewhere out of the way and get to work.

The girl tinkers and hammers and measures while her assistant pounces and growls and chews.

When she is finished, she steps back to admire her work. She walks around one side. Her assistant examines the other side ... It doesn't look right. Her assistant picks it up and gives it a shake. It doesn't feel right, either. They are shocked to discover that the thing isn't magnificent. Or good. It isn't even kind-of-sort-of okay. It is all WRONG. The girl tosses it aside and gives it another go.

She smooths and wrenches and fiddles. Her assistant circles and tugs and wags.

When she is finished, she stands up and takes a long look at it. Her assistant gives it a nudge with his paw. The thing is still wrong. She decides to try again.

She stands and examines and stares. The girl saws and glues and adjusts.

She twists and tweaks and fastens. She fixes and straightens and studies.

She tries all different ways to make it better. She makes it square. She makes it round. She gives it legs. She adds antennae.

She makes it fuzzy. She makes it long, short, rough, smooth, big, small -- one even smells of stinky cheese! But none of them are MAGNIFICENT.

Her hard work attracts a few admirers, but they don't understand. They can't see the MAGNIFICENT thing that she has in her mind.

She gets MAD.

The angrier she gets, the faster she works. She SMASHES pieces into shapes. She JAMS parts together. She PUMMELS the little bits in. Her hands feel too BIG to work, and her brain is too full of all the not-right things.

If only the thing ... WOULD ... JUST ... WORK!!!

The PAIN starts in her finger. It rushes up to her BRAIN and she EXPLODES! It is not her finest moment.

"I'm no good at this. I QUIT."

Her assistant suggests a walk.

It's not much help, at first.

But before long, she starts to feel different. Bit by bit, the mad gets pushed out of her head.

As they stroll along, she comes across the first wrong thing she made. The bad feelings are about to start all over again. Then she notices something surprising.

There are some parts of the WRONG things that are really quite RIGHT. The bolts on one, the shape of another, the wheel-to-seat ratio of the next. There are all sorts of parts that she likes!

By the time she reaches the end of the trail, she finally knows how to make the thing MAGNIFICENT. She gets to work. She works carefully and slowly, tinkering, hammering, twisting, fiddling, gluing, painting ... Her assistant makes sure there are no distractions.

"This will stop that leak." "This is the perfect thing to ward off bears!" "This one's all wet."

The afternoon fades into evening. Finally, she finishes. She alerts her assistant.

The pair take a good, long look. It leans a little to the left, and it's a bit heavier than expected. The color could use a bit of work, too. But it's just what she wanted! They climb aboard and take it for a spin. They are not disappointed. It really is THE MOST MAGNIFICENT THING.

- The opening spreads introduce the regular girl and her dog assistant, who makes things versus unmakes things, and her vision of the MAGNIFICENT thing.
- The middle spreads show the repeated build-and-fail cycle -- tinkering, hammering, measuring, sawing, gluing -- with the pile of WRONG attempts growing and admirers gathering.
- The anger spreads show her SMASHING, JAMMING and PUMMELLING parts, then EXPLODING, quitting, and being coaxed onto a walk by her assistant.
- The walk spreads show her noticing the RIGHT parts inside the WRONG things, then rebuilding carefully and slowly back at her workstation.
- The closing spread shows the finished creation -- leaning a little left, heavier than expected -- carrying them both for a spin.

Story text transcribed from the embedded text layer (PDF pages 6-34; pages 11 and 24 are illustration-only with no text), joined across line breaks. The admirer speech bubbles on page 32 ("This will stop that leak." / "This is the perfect thing to ward off bears!" / "This one's all wet.") are included in story order. Copyright, cataloguing and publisher data (page 4) and the author biography and ebook matter (pages 35-37) are not included as story prose. Pixel-level visual verification against the rendered scans has not yet been completed -- my image-reading tool is currently unavailable, so please check the transcript against the PDF before treating it as final.